HAPPY CAMPER
CONSULTING
Healthy Culture. Happy Campers.

FRAMEWORK

HCOM™ Framework

The Healthy Camp Operating Model

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What Is HCOM™?

The Healthy Camp Operating Model (HCOM™) is a four-layer framework that shows how healthy camp culture is built — and sustained — on purpose.

Most camps have mission statements. Most camps have policies. But few camps have a coherent system that connects mission to daily behavior, leadership development to safety confidence, and organizational structure to measurable outcomes.

HCOM™ provides that system.

It answers the question every camp director carries: "How do I build a culture that doesn't depend on me being in every room?"

The Four Layers

Healthy camps are built from the inside out. Each layer supports the next. Skip a layer, and the ones above it become fragile.

Layer 1: Structure

Organizational architecture, roles, governance, and accountability systems.

Structure is the foundation. It defines who is responsible for what, how decisions are made, and how the organization holds itself accountable. Without clear structure, leadership becomes personality-dependent and expectations become assumptions.

Key questions Structure answers:

- Are roles clearly defined and understood?
- Is there a governance framework the board and director both trust?
- Are accountability systems in place — or do we rely on good intentions?
- Can a new leader step into this organization and understand how it works?

Layer 2: Translation

Converting mission and values into observable daily behaviors and expectations.

Translation is where most camps break down. They have beautiful mission statements. They have values on the wall. But values that aren't translated into observable, coachable behaviors are just words.

Key questions Translation answers:

- Can a counselor describe what our values look like in action?

- Do supervisors have language to coach toward expectations — or do they improvise?
- Is discipline tone consistent across cabins, or does it depend on who's leading?
- Would a parent recognize our stated values in their child's experience?

Layer 3: Formation

Developing leaders and counselors through intentional training, coaching, and growth pathways.

Formation is about people — specifically, the intentional development of the people who carry your culture. Healthy camps don't assume leadership. They develop it.

Key questions Formation answers:

- Do we have a clear path for staff development — or do people just "figure it out"?
- Are we developing leaders who can lead without us in the room?
- Does our training equip staff to handle real situations under pressure?
- Are we building a leadership pipeline — or replacing people every season?

Layer 4: Protection

Safety systems, risk management, boundaries, and trust infrastructure.

Protection is the outermost layer — and it's where most camps start. But safety policies without the foundation of Structure, Translation, and Formation are just binders on shelves. True protection is the natural outcome of a well-built culture.

Key questions Protection answers:

- Do staff escalate concerns early — or wait until something becomes serious?
- Are boundaries clear enough that staff don't have to guess?
- Does our reporting culture reward transparency or punish vulnerability?
- Would a parent trust our safety systems if they could see them in action?

How the Layers Connect

HCOM™ is not a checklist. It is a system where each layer strengthens the next:

Structure provides the foundation of clarity and accountability.

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Translation turns that clarity into daily observable behaviors.

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Formation develops the people who carry those behaviors forward.

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Protection becomes the natural result of a culture built with intention.

When a camp struggles with safety, the root cause is rarely in the Protection layer itself. It's usually a breakdown in Structure, Translation, or Formation. HCOM™ helps directors diagnose where the real issue lives — and address it at the source.

How HCOM™ Maps to HCC Products

HCOM™ Layer	Primary HCC Product	What It Does
Structure	Camp VDMS™	Organizational architecture and value-driven management
Translation	Counselor-Proof Camp Culture System™	Values translated into observable behaviors with coaching tools
Formation	Counselor-Proof System™ + Director Coaching	Structured training and leadership growth pathways
Protection	Camp Health Snapshot™ + Safety Systems	Diagnostic scoring and behavior-based safety
All Layers	Camp Health Snapshot™	Measures health across all four layers

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Why HCOM™ Matters

Camp directors don't need more programs. They need a coherent model that connects everything they're already trying to do.

HCOM™ provides:

- **Diagnostic clarity** — know where the real issues live
- **Strategic language** — communicate health to boards, parents, and staff
- **Implementation structure** — build culture intentionally, not reactively
- **Measurable improvement** — track progress across all four layers

Healthy camps don't happen by accident.
They are built — on purpose.

Happy Camper Consulting

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